Clippers sail on

Clearview's boys have no problem with Columbia, roll into Division III sectional finals.
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SPORTS

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Section C

Thursday, February 24, 2005

INDIANS

No way, Jose

Gonzalez calls Canseco liar, says he never took steroids

Fred Goodall
The Associated Press

WINTER HAVEN, Fla. — Juan Gonzalez hasn't read Jose Canseco's book and doesn't want to.

The Cleveland slugger became the latest player to refute allegations made by his former teammate, saying Wednesday he has never used performance-enhancing drugs and that Canseco lied about introducing the two-time AL MVP to steroids in the early 1990s.


Gonzalez

"It's not true. ... I never saw needles. I never saw pills. I never saw anything. ... The only guys who have put needles in my body are doctors," Gonzalez said.

In his new book, Canseco claims he educated Gonzalez, Ivan Rodriguez and Rafael Palmeiro about steroids after being traded to Texas in 1992. Rodriguez and Palmeiro also have denied using performance-enhancing drugs.

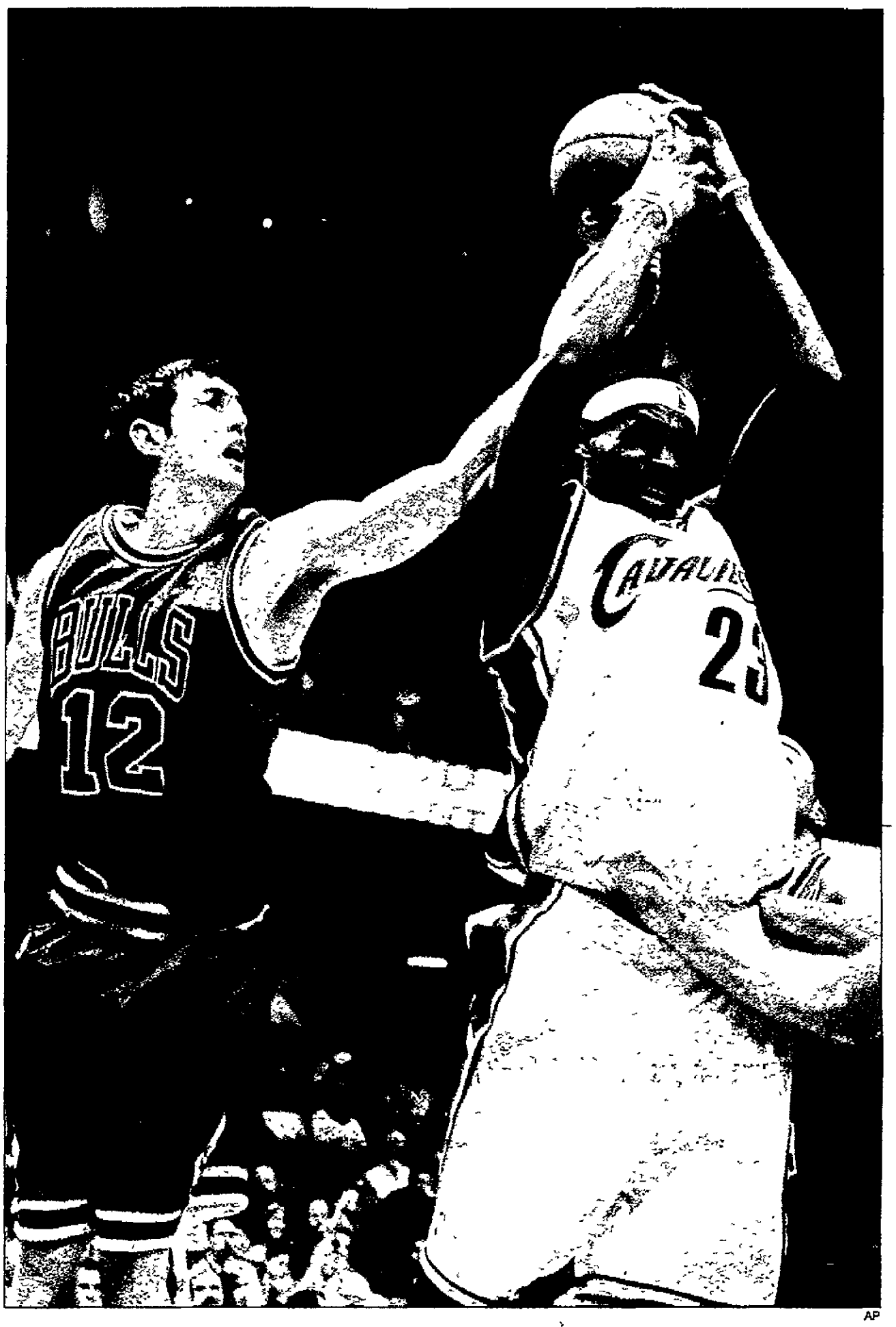
Gonzalez, joined at a news conference by agent Alan Nero, said his comments following a workout at Chain of Lakes Park would be his last about Canseco, who said he injected Gonzalez and others with steroids

"I feel sorry for Canseco. ... His comments hurt my feelings," Gonzalez said, adding that he's willing to take a test to prove he's clean. "People who know me a long time in this game (know) I've never had problems with anybody ... I have a clear mind and clear heart."

See **INDIANS**, C5

CAVALIERS 100, BULLS 91

All-Stars in alignment


AP

LeBron James (23) and the Bulls' Kirk Hinrich battle for the ball during the second quarter Wednesday night at Gund Arena. James scored 27 points and handed out 11 assists in the Cavaliers' win.

Ilgauskas, James take over game, carry Cavs to win

Rick Noland
The Chronicle-Telegram

CLEVELAND — The All-Star break is over, but Zydrunas Ilgauskas and LeBron James aren't done playing like All-Stars.


Ilgauskas

The two most important Cavaliers combined for 60 points Wednesday night as the Cavaliers downed the tired but relentless Chicago Bulls 100-91 in front of a sellout crowd at Gund Arena.

"We're the two All-Stars on the team and we're All-Stars for a reason," said James, who had 27 points, six rebounds, 11 assists and five steals "We showed why tonight If we don't come out and lead like that, it's going to be hard for us to win."

From 7.18 of the third period until 3.54 of the fourth, Ilgauskas and James combined to score 35 straight Cavalier points. Eighteen came to end the third, with 17 more coming at the start of the fourth.

"Z especially just stepped up big-time," Cavaliers coach Paul Silas said. "You kind of expect it out of LeBron. If (Ilgauskas) continues to do this the second half of this year, we've got a chance to do something really special."

Ilgauskas finished with 33 points, 26 of which came in the second half. Sixteen of those came in the third period The 7-foot-3 center, who sat the last 4:14 after picking up his fifth foul, added eight rebounds and seven blocks.

"He's been playing this way, but not to this magnitude," Silas said. "We needed it tonight, and he provided it."

The most impressive thing about Ilgauskas' performance was that it came while playing against 6-11 Eddy Curry, who said he should have made the All-Star team in place of the Cavs center, and 7-1 Tyson Chandler

"He's definitely a handful," said

See **CAVS**, C5

NEXT UP

WHO: Cleveland at Indiana
WHEN: Friday, 8 p.m.
WHERE: Canseco Fieldhouse, Indianapolis
TV/RADIO: FSN Ohio, ESPN; WTAM 1100-AM

BOYS BASKETBALL

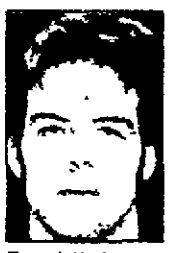
Falls gets revenge, thanks to Braddick

Roger Negin
The Chronicle-Telegram

GRAFTON — Pat Braddick wouldn't let Olmsted Falls die.

The lone starter from last year's district championship team was the one who made the plays in overtime to lead the fourth-ranked Bulldogs to a 50-48 victory over Southwestern Conference rival North Olmsted in Division I sectional tournament play Wednesday.

After losing two to the Eagles during the regular season, Braddick made sure it didn't happen a third time. He hit a 3-pointer to put the Bulldogs ahead, followed it up with a huge steal with Olmsted Falls clinging to a two-point lead and


Braddick

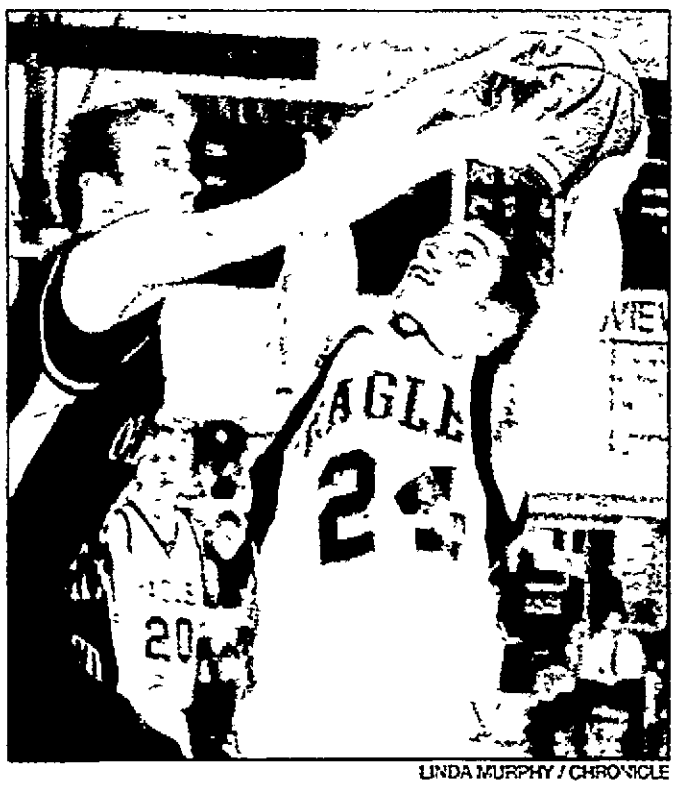
sank two free throws with 13 seconds left to ice it.

Braddick is accustomed to success, leading the Bulldogs to their 10th straight SWC championship this year.

"It feels natural," said Braddick, who had a huge game in last year's district title game victory over Lakewood St. Edward.

"Pat's a gamer, there's no question about it," said Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue.

See **FALLS**, C2


LINDA MURPHY / CHRONICLE

Olmsted Falls' Corey Sparks blocks Chris Hibinger's shot Wednesday as the 'Dogs beat North Olmsted for the first time in three tries this season.

STATE WRESTLING

Palmer out to pin his way to 3rd title

Judie Asp
The Chronicle-Telegram

Lance Palmer sets goals and meets them. And they aren't your normal, everyday goals either.

This season, the 125-pound St. Edward wrestler from Columbia Station, set his sites on a perfectly reasonable goal ... for him.

The goal? To win his third state championship

Of course, that wasn't enough for Palmer. No, he had to add a second goal: to pin every opponent he faces in the postseason.

So far, so good.

"When sectionals start, I call it my season." Palmer said. "I get excited about it every year because it's what I've worked so hard for. It's sort of weird because something just clicks in my head and I'm ready to go."

See **PALMER**, C3

ON C3

PIONEER PLAN: Elyria coach Erik Burnett believes his big six can do big things.
LOCAL FLAVOR: Twenty-one area wrestlers begin their dreams of a state title today in Columbus. Read up on each and every one.

